



Charlemagne's coronation

Pope Leo III crowned Charlemagne emperor on Christmas Day 800 CE. Charlemagne said he did not want to be crowned by Leo, perhaps because by "giving" the emperor the crown, Leo appeared the more powerful of the two.

adoption of the title was justified by the fact that the throne of the Eastern Roman Empire in Constantinople (see BEFORE) was held by a woman, the Empress Irene and so theoretically vacant. Charlemagne's seal included the Latin tag *renovatio Romani imperii* ("renovation of the Roman Empire") and he is portrayed on coins, in deliberate imitation of the Roman emperors, wearing a military cloak and laurel crown.

Charlemagne himself had doubts about a title that tied him so closely to Rome, and in 813 he held a purely Frankish ceremony for the coronation of his son, Louis the Pious.

After Charlemagne

Louis the Pious was an intelligent and well-educated man, but he lacked his father's leadership abilities. When he died in 840, the empire was divided between his three sons, who quarreled and in turn had multiple heirs, so the great Carolingian empire was further split. In addition, the security of Europe was threatened by invasions from several directions—Scandinavian Vikings from the north (see pp.202–03), Arabs from the south, and Magyars who had moved into what is now Hungary from farther east. Over the course of the late 9th and early 10th centuries, Western Europe fragmented into many small states, governed by local rulers and Carolingian heirs.

In 911, the last of the eastern Carolingian rulers, Louis the Child, died, and a group of German dukes banded together to choose a king for their lands. The resulting line of rulers,

pious emperor." This use of oaths to create a direct relationship between ruler and subjects reflects the lack of more complex administrative structures, such as had existed in the Roman Empire. Charlemagne made many administrative reforms and created a more efficient bureaucracy than had existed under his predecessors, but he continued to depend on a handful of officials drawn from the local aristocracy. Military action, in

particular, required a large degree of consensus among the nobility.

Imperial authority

Charlemagne also sought to develop the imperial dimension of his rule, borrowing from the authority of the Roman emperors. In 800 he went to Rome to reinstate Pope Leo III and, on Christmas day, he was crowned "Emperor of the Romans." This

"[Charlemagne] energetically **promoted the liberal arts** and praised and honored those who taught them."

EINHARD, HISTORIAN AND COURTIER, FROM "LIFE OF CHARLEMAGNE," c. 827 CE



Battle of Lechfeld

In 955 CE Otto I decisively defeated the Magyars at Lechfeld, near Augsburg, in Germany. The battle ended the threat from the Magyars, who had taken advantage of divisions in Western Europe to mount their invasion.

most of whom were from Saxony in eastern Germany, grew steadily more powerful. The most successful of them all was Otto I (reigned 936–73 CE). Otto benefited from a discovery of silver in the Harz Mountains in Saxony in 938, which gave him the wealth to pay for a huge army and build a string of fortified towns. He pushed the boundaries of his German empire eastward, inflicting a major defeat on the Magyars at the Battle of Lechfeld in 955 (see above).

Like Charlemagne before him, Otto cultivated the church, encouraging the conversion of non-Christians in his realm and founding new bishoprics. He appointed his own nominees as abbots and bishops and sought to strengthen the authority of the church at the expense of the secular nobility.



ANGLO-SAXON KING (c. 849–899 CE)

KING ALFRED

Alfred the Great inherited the throne of Wessex (southern England) in 871 CE. At the Battle of Edington in 878, he defeated the Danes, who had already occupied north and eastern England and were attacking Wessex. Basing his style of rule on that of Charlemagne, he strengthened his kingdom against further attacks, building fortified towns and establishing a navy. Alfred, like Charlemagne, also promoted education and the arts. He left his kingdom much stronger than he found it, and he laid the foundations for his successors to unite England under a single ruler.

